uniquely, identified.

Akbar would have known, of course, that warlords would not like being forced to give account of their armies, and so he called Aziz, his oldest friend, to help him. Perhaps he imagined that Aziz would gallop east from Ahmedabad as eagerly as Akbar had once galloped to Aziz's aid. If so, Aziz's reaction to Akbar's offer came as a rude shock.

Aziz used such 'language about . . . branding', writes Abul Fazl, that even 'men of ordinary prudence would not use' – let alone trusted friends. Badauni says that the conversation was more widely condemnatory of Akbar's policies: 'Everything that [Aziz] knew about these things he mentioned with unqualified disapprobation.' Furious, Akbar demoted his friend, banned him from court, and put him under house arrest. Others whose corruption was revealed by branding (those who 'collected gold instead of troops',[17] that is) were banished to Bengal for Munim Khan to deal with – in the very month, as it happens, that Munim Khan died.

It was three years – in October 1578 – before Aziz was released, and another sixteen before the two friends were properly reconciled, but not once, in all that time, did Akbar hesitate to go ahead with his plans, even if he admitted they weren't perfect.

Badauni writes with disgust of fief-holders who, before Akbar's reforms, only 'amassed wealth' and had little interest in looking after their soldiers and peasants; and who, after the mansabdari system came into effect, would dress their servants in soldiers' clothes for the sake of their salary, while 'dust fell into the platter of the helpless soldier'. These new systems were amenable to other kinds of fraud, too. All kinds of people, 'tradespeople, weavers and cotton cleaners, carpenters, and green-grocers, both Hindu and Musalman', seeing an opportunity for a quick buck, 'borrowed horses, got them branded, and were appointed to a command'. Having pocketed a salary, the men faded from view: 'a few days afterwards no trace was to be found of the imaginary horse and the visionary saddle'. Akbar was well aware of this latter fraud, writes Badauni, but chose to let it slide, saying, 'With my eyes thus open I must give these men pay, that they may have something to live on.'

It wasn't the case, however, that mansabdari at these lower ranks was a kind of imperial charity; in fact, it was a whole reimagination of the idea of